

The Act of Peter

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Douglas M. Parrott

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The Act of Peter is a narrative about how the virginity of Peter's daughter was preserved and the soul of one Ptolemy saved, by divine intervention exercised through Peter. The setting of Act Pet. is a Sunday (the place is not mentioned; cf. discussion below), when, it appears, it was customary for Peter to conduct his healing ministry. A challenge by one of the bystanders leads Peter to employ the power of God to heal his daughter of paralysis, which healing he immediately reverses (128,7-131,9). Peter's narrative, which constitutes most of the remainder of Act Pet., begins with an explanation of how his daughter came to be paralyzed. When she had grown to sexual maturity, the girl was so attractive that a rich man named Ptolemy burned with desire to marry her. Her mother refused permission, whereupon Ptolemy abducted her. If the operative law was Jewish, Ptolemy's purpose may well have been to force the girl's parents to allow him to marry her (see Dt 22:28-29). Peter's prayers caused her to be paralyzed before Ptolemy could have intercourse with her, and hence her virginity was preserved (131,12-135,17). Ptolemy went blind with grief, but a vision spared him from suicide, revealed his guilt, and sent him to Peter, where his sight was restored and his soul was made to see also (135,17-138,10). Thereafter he lived an exemplary life and gave Peter and his daughter a parcel of land when he died. This Peter sold and gave the proceeds to the poor (138,12-139,17). Peter draws the moral that God cares for his own, and the whole account ends with Peter distributing bread to the crowd and retiring to his home.

Although the physical setting is not mentioned in the text, it is reasonable to think of Jerusalem, since Peter's home is spoken of (141,6), where he lives with his wife and daughter (135,1-6). Another possibility is Rome, but there is a tradition in *The Acts of Peter*, mentioned below, that he goes alone to Rome. In addition, as noted above, the operative law appears to be Jewish.

The Act of Peter probably was part of the otherwise lost beginning third of a collection of apocryphal narratives known as *The Acts of Peter*. There is extensive conceptual and literary agreement between The Act of Peter and the remaining Acts of Peter. Whether there is a close enough relationship between The Act of Peter and the Nag Hammadi *Acts of Peter and the Twelve Apostles* (VI, 7) to make it likely that the latter was also part of *The Acts of Peter* remains to be seen.

Conceptually, the emphasis of The Act of Peter is moderately encratite. Marriage itself is not denounced (note that Peter was married and still living with his wife). What is denounced is Ptolemy's lust, which leads him to attempt to deprive a Christian maiden of her virginity by force (137,1-11). Thus, the encratism in this tractate consists in its advocacy of rigorous sexual

self-control, which was a view common among Christians in the second century. There is no doubt, however, that the lack of any statement about the meaning of the narrative would have allowed it to be interpreted in a more extreme sense.

It has been suggested that the reason for the inclusion of The Act of Peter in a codex containing three explicitly gnostic tractates is that the scribe needed to fill up the pages after copying the first three tractates, and thus he was attracted to The Act of Peter by its appropriate length and the encratite tendencies in it. Considering the large amount of explicitly gnostic writing available, one wonders why he chose a work only marginally related. The editor might have been influenced by the immediately preceding tractate, *The Sophia of Jesus Christ*, which has in its conclusion, when Christ disappears from the disciples, the statement that they “began to preach the Gospel of God, the eternal Father” (129,5-9). He might have thought that an account of apostolic activity would be appropriate. But since many similar accounts would also have been circulating, there may be a further reason for the choice of this particular tractate.

The Act of Peter may have been chosen because of the rich possibilities for allegorization that it would have presented to Gnostics. Ptolemy could have represented the soul, whose attraction to the things of the world (represented by the beauty of Peter’s daughter) leads to ignorance (represented by grief and blindness), and would have led to death except for the coming of the light of true knowledge (in Act Pet., the vision of light and the voice of Christ [136,17-137,17]), which removes blindness (138,7-10). The paralysis of the daughter could have represented the power of divine knowledge over the powers of this world; and, of course, the daughter could also have been seen as a type of the fallen Sophia. (For related gnostic views in BG, cf. *Soph. Jes. Chr.* [BG,5] 103,10-106,9; 117,13-126,16). It may thus have been the deeper meanings seen in this text that attracted the gnostic compiler to it and led him to use it in the codex.

Act Pt. are dated toward the end of the second century. Hence Act Pet. would have been extant by that time, although it might well have had an earlier, independent existence.